Module 4, Lesson 4.1: Email Management Automation

The Email Problem

Let's be honest about email: for most professionals, it's a persistent problem.

- Your inbox grows faster than you can process it
- Important messages get buried under noise
- The same types of emails arrive repeatedly
- Responding consumes hours that could be spent on higher-value work

The average professional spends 28% of their workday on email. That's over 2 hours every day, or more than 10 hours per week. What could you do with an extra 10 hours?

Email management is the perfect starting point for AI automation because:

1. It's repetitive and rule-based
2. The patterns are predictable
3. The volume justifies automation
4. The time savings are immediate and measurable

What AI Email Automation Looks Like

Before we dive into implementation, let's clarify what's possible:

Level 1: Email Intelligence

Your AI agent monitors your inbox and:

- Summarizes what's new

- Highlights important messages
- Identifies action items
- Surfaces urgent items

You still read and respond, but you're informed rather than overwhelmed.

Level 2: Email Assistance

Your AI agent actively helps:

- Drafts responses for routine emails
- Categorizes incoming messages
- Files emails into appropriate folders
- Suggests follow-up actions

You review drafts and make decisions, but the heavy lifting is done.

Level 3: Email Automation

Your AI agent handles routine email autonomously:

- Responds to common inquiries automatically
- Handles scheduling and confirmation emails
- Processes newsletters and notifications
- Escalates only what needs human attention

You're involved only in exceptions and high-value communications.

We'll build toward Level 3, starting with Level 1 and progressively adding automation as you become comfortable.

Setting Up Email Integration

Configuration

Add email configuration to your OpenClaw config:

```yaml
email:
  provider: gmail  # or outlook, imap

  # Permissions
  read: true       # Can read your emails
  write: true      # Can send on your behalf
  delete: false    # Cannot delete (safety)

  # Safety settings
  require_confirmation: true  # Always confirm before sending
  draft_mode: true           # Start in draft mode

  # Filters
  exclude_folders:
    - spam
    - trash
  include_labels:
    - inbox
    - important
```

Connecting Your Email

For Gmail:

1. Enable IMAP in Gmail settings
2. Create an app password (if using 2FA)
3. Configure in OpenClaw

For Outlook:

1. Enable IMAP or use OAuth
2. Configure credentials

For other providers:

1. Use the IMAP configuration
2. Provide server details and credentials

Safety First

Before giving your AI access to email, establish guardrails:

In AGENTS.md:

```
## Email Safety Rules

NEVER:
- Send emails without my review (initially)
- Delete emails
- Respond to sensitive topics automatically
- Share email contents externally
- Respond to spam or suspicious emails

ALWAYS:
- Draft responses for my review
- Flag sensitive or important emails
- Categorize before processing
- Ask for guidance on ambiguous situations
```

Email Intelligence: Reading and Summarizing

Start with read-only capabilities:

Daily Email Summary

Prompt your agent: “Give me a summary of my inbox. What’s new, what’s important, what needs action?”

Your agent will:

- Read unread emails
- Identify senders and subjects
- Flag important items
- Note action items
- Provide a concise summary

Example Output

```
📧 Inbox Summary - 47 emails (12 unread)

🔴 Urgent/Action Required:
- Sarah (Acme Corp): Contract revision needed by EOD
- Bank: Unusual activity alert - requires review

🟡 Important:
- John: Meeting reschedule request
- Newsletter: Industry report with insights
- Client: Project milestone update

🔵 Newsletters/Notifications:
- 8 newsletters (can bulk archive)
- 12 promotional emails
- 5 social notifications

📝 Action Items Identified:
1. Review and respond to Sarah's contract revision
2. Check bank activity alert
3. Confirm meeting reschedule with John

💡 Suggested Response:
Would you like me to draft responses for any of these?
```

Customized Summaries

Tailor summaries to your needs:

“Show me only emails from clients.” “What emails need a response today?” “Summarize everything from the past 3 days.”

Identifying Patterns

After monitoring your email for a week:

“Analyze my email patterns. What types of emails do I receive most? Who are my most frequent senders? What patterns do you notice?”

Your agent can identify:

- High-frequency senders
- Email types that could be automated
- Response patterns
- Time-of-day patterns

Email Assistance: Drafting and Organizing

Once you're comfortable with email intelligence, add assistance capabilities:

Drafting Responses

For routine emails, your agent can draft responses:

Scenario: Scheduling Request

```
Email from John: "Hey, can we move our Thursday meeting to Friday?"

Your agent drafts:
"Hi John, Friday works for me. Would 2 PM work on your end? Let me know and
I'll send a calendar invite."

[Draft saved. Review and send?]
```

Scenario: Information Request

```
Email from prospect: "What are your consulting rates?"

Your agent drafts:
"Thanks for reaching out! My consulting rates vary based on project scope
and complexity. For AI automation consulting, I typically work on either a
project basis ($X-Y per project) or hourly ($X/hour). Would you like to
schedule a brief call to discuss your specific needs? I'd be happy to
provide a more tailored quote."

[Draft saved. Review and send?]
```

Templates for Common Emails

Create templates for frequent email types:

In your workspace:

```
Resources/email-templates/
├── pricing-inquiry.md
├── meeting-request.md
├── project-update.md
├── thank-you.md
└── follow-up.md
```

Example template:

```md
# Pricing Inquiry Response

Subject: Re: [Original Subject]

Hi [Name],

Thanks for your interest in [service]!

[Standard pricing explanation]

[Brief value proposition]

[Call to action - typically a call or meeting]

Let me know if you have any questions!

Best,
[Your name]
```

Your agent will personalize templates based on the email context.

Email Categorization

Automatically categorize incoming emails:

```
## Email Categories

### Clients
- Emails from client domains
- Emails about active projects
- Contract and billing discussions

### Prospects
- Inquiries about services
- Follow-ups from networking
- Demo requests

### Operational
- Scheduling and logistics
- Team communications
- Vendor correspondence

### Newsletters
- Industry newsletters
- Promotional emails
- Notifications

### Personal
- Non-work contacts
- Personal matters
```

Your agent can file emails into categories automatically or suggest categories for your review.

Email Automation: Handling Routine Email

The ultimate goal is handling routine email without your involvement:

What Can Be Automated

Fully Automated (No Review Needed):

- Newsletter subscriptions (archive or read-later)
- Promotional emails (delete or archive)
- Receipt notifications (file and ignore)

- Calendar invites (auto-accept routine meetings)

Semi-Automated (Quick Review):

- Standard inquiries (drafted response, one-click send)
- Scheduling requests (proposed times, quick confirm)
- Follow-ups (drafted, review and personalize)

Human Required (Alert Only):

- Client issues or complaints
- Contract negotiations
- Sensitive personnel matters
- Anything from VIP contacts

Setting Up Automation Rules

Define rules in your configuration:

```
## Email Automation Rules

### Fully Automated
- Newsletters from [list] → Archive
- Receipts from [list] → File in Receipts folder
- Social notifications → Archive after 24 hours
- Calendar invites from known contacts → Accept if available

### Semi-Automated
- Pricing inquiries → Draft response, flag for review
- Meeting requests → Propose times, flag for confirmation
- Follow-ups → Draft response, flag for review

### Human Required
- Emails from [VIP list] → Flag as urgent
- Emails containing [urgent keywords] → Flag as urgent
- Client emails → Highlight and draft response
- Anything with [contract, legal, complaint] → Flag as priority
```

VIP List

Maintain a list of contacts who should always get human attention:

```
## VIP Contacts
- [Client name] at [company]
- [Partner name] at [company]
- [Key contact] at [important organization]
- Family members
```

Urgent Keywords

Flag emails containing these keywords for immediate attention:

```
## Urgent Keywords
- urgent
- asap
- deadline
- contract
- legal
- complaint
- problem
- issue
- cancel
- refund
```

Building Your Email Workflow

Morning Routine

```
📧 Morning Email Routine

1. Summarize overnight emails
2. Highlight urgent items
3. Draft responses for routine items
4. Identify newsletters to archive
5. Flag items needing attention
```

Prompt: “Run my morning email routine.”

End-of-Day Routine

```
📧 Evening Email Routine

1. Summarize today's email activity
2. Confirm all action items addressed
3. Draft any pending responses
4. Archive processed emails
5. Set up for tomorrow
```

Prompt: “Run my evening email routine.”

Weekly Review

```
📧 Weekly Email Review

1. Analyze email volume and patterns
2. Review automation effectiveness
3. Update rules based on patterns
4. Clean up templates
5. Identify new automation opportunities
```

Prompt: “Review my email from this week. What patterns do you notice? What could be further automated?”

Measuring Email Automation Success

Track these metrics to measure improvement:

Time Spent on Email

- Before automation: ___ hours/week
- After automation: ___ hours/week
- Time saved: ___ hours/week

Inbox Management

- Unread emails at end of day: Before __, *After* __
- Average response time: Before __, *After* __
- Missed important emails: Before __, *After* __

Automation Rate

- Emails fully automated: ___%
- Emails drafted (one-click send): ___%
- Emails requiring full attention: ___%

Quality

- Response appropriateness: Good/Needs work
- Client satisfaction: Any feedback?
- Missed opportunities: Any regrets?

Advanced Email Automation

Smart Filters

Create dynamic filters that learn:

“Any email from a new sender asking about services should be categorized as a prospect inquiry.”

“Any email mentioning [project name] should be flagged as project-related.”

Response Learning

Your agent can learn your response style:

“For similar inquiry types, draft responses similar to how I’ve responded before.”

“Notice how I typically respond to pricing questions and draft in that style.”

Follow-Up Automation

Automate follow-ups:

“If I haven’t responded to a client email within 48 hours, remind me.”

“For prospect inquiries, if no response in 24 hours, draft a follow-up.”

Integration with Calendar

Connect email and calendar:

“When someone requests a meeting, check my calendar and propose 3 available times.”

“When meeting is confirmed, send a confirmation email automatically.”

Email Automation Best Practices

Start Conservative

1. Begin with read-only access
2. Add drafting capability
3. Add organization features
4. Finally, add sending capability

You can always increase automation. You can’t undo a sent email.

Always Have a Review Step

Even for routine emails, maintain a review step until you’re confident:

- The agent understands your voice
- Responses are appropriate
- No embarrassing mistakes

Keep VIPs Human

Never automate responses to:

- Key clients
- Your boss
- Family
- Anyone who expects personal attention

Maintain Escalation Paths

Always have a way to:

- Flag urgent items
- Override automation
- Pause automation if needed

Review Regularly

Weekly reviews of:

- What was automated
- What was missed
- What needs adjustment

Coming Up Next

In Lesson 4.2, we'll tackle calendar intelligence—automating scheduling, managing commitments, and making your calendar work for you instead of against you.

Key Takeaways

1. **Start with intelligence, build to automation** - Read before you write, draft before you send
2. **Safety first** - Guardrails, confirmation steps, and human review
3. **Categorize ruthlessly** - Different email types deserve different automation levels
4. **Measure your savings** - Track time, quality, and automation rate
5. **Always maintain VIP human attention** - Some emails should never be automated